can’t predict what’s going to ail people: one person’s bigness is another person’s smallness, and it was obvious already that we were being characterised as mavericks who stepped on people’s toes. I’m sure we could have been more sensitive to that, but the issues seemed to me too pressing for social or professional niceties, and I guess I wrongly assumed Ms Wrong would be pleased to know her book was so appreciated. Maybe I was over-zealous, but you get like that when the stakes are so high and the conditions so desperate.

We had to learn to deal with resistance. Another person we had admired, a transparency activist called Steven Aftergood, head of the Federation of American Scientists Secrecy Project and someone I had originally hoped to recruit to our advisory board, also came after us from our own side. When it came to government corruption, we imagined we could begin to become the people’s silent advocate in the room. But often we found the prosecution side included people we thought we might have counted on for guidance, for support, for encouragement, or just for tolerance. Aftergood attacked our editorial judgement, feeling some of our targets were undeserving or unworthy of scrutiny – the Church of Scientology, for instance, or the operating manual for the US military’s guided bombs – while other work of ours he felt to be ‘irresponsible’.

It was never my intention to be responsible in the sense that Aftergood understands the word. We are not of a party or a state; our remit is neither national nor corporate, and we hold no candle for one grouping over another. Unlike too many media organisations, we are not *parti pris*. We will shine a light into any murky corner. When Aftergood spoke of responsibility, he was invoking a misnomer: what he really meant, though he couldn’t see it, was that we should take on trust the idea that some secrets have to be kept secret just because a powerful and interested party said so. He knows too much about the self-serving nature of modern government to imagine that we could ever take such a thing on trust. And neither should he. The fact was our organisation was taking a tough new stand. Invading people’s privacy, as he put it at the time, was no great crime in my book, not when the potential crimes of the people whose privacy we were invading were evidently so great and so covered up. Aftergood disliked some of the same things we did, but he wasn’t willing to shake them down. He was timid. And, like so many, he was probably dismayed at